Do constrained career pathways amplify political reactions to economic shocks?

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1. Research problem and gap

Neffke et al. (2017) show that worker transitions reveal structured pathways of transferable skills across industries. Tóth, Elekes and Eriksson (2026) separate occupational skill similarity from actual worker mobility and show that skill-aligned mobility (SAM) varies across Swedish regions and demographic groups, and the differences are associated with labor-market outcomes. Elekes, Tóth and Eriksson (2024) find that regional labour-flow network robustness predicts employment responses to the 2008 crisis. Meanwhile, Algan et al. (2017) link adverse labour-market shocks to greater support for non-mainstream parties in European regions.

Gap: We know that economic insecurity is associated with voting behaviour and that labour markets differ in their ability to redeploy skills. Less is known about whether the alignment of actual career transitions with transferable skills helps explain why similarly exposed regions react differently to economic shocks at the ballot box.

2. Research questions, hypotheses and network mechanism

RQ1: Is lower pre-shock SAM associated with subsequent increases in anti-establishment vote share?

RQ2: Is this association stronger in regions exposed to larger negative employment shocks?

H1: Regions with lower SAM experience larger subsequent electoral shifts toward anti-establishment parties, conditional on baseline economic conditions.

H2: This relationship is stronger when negative employment shocks occur. Mechanism: workers may possess skills relevant to other occupations yet lack effective routes into suitable jobs; an adverse shock could therefore produce more persistent insecurity and dissatisfaction where mobility pathways function poorly. We do not presume that such reactions favour a particular side of the left–right spectrum.

3. Data, networks and empirical strategy

Occupational skills (Europe). The European Commission's ESCO occupation–skill classification provides downloadable occupations, associated skills and ISCO mappings. We would construct one reference occupation–skill matrix, aggregate to comparable ISCO categories and use cosine similarity for weighted network links. This is a standardized measure of potential skill transfer, not country-specific recruitment demand.

Actual transitions (Europe). The OECD LinkEED 2.0 project offers a practical model for harmonised analyses of confidential national linked employer–employee records. Its 2025 International Migration Outlook analysis used longitudinal data from 15 OECD countries (10 EU members), tracking movements among firms, industries and, where available, occupations. This is evidence of national data infrastructure—not a downloadable EU-wide microdataset. Access, regional identifiers, occupation detail and time coverage differ across countries; national researchers could estimate comparable regional outcomes locally.

Elections and parties (Europe). BLUE_DB provides open municipal-level national and European Parliament results for 31 countries, 2001–2025, with party identifiers. We would aggregate these to the labour-market regions used for SAM. Party classifications could be matched to CHES (ideology, anti-elite positions) and The PopuList (populist and radical party families); classifications and coalition changes would require harmonisation over time.

Measurement and model. Nodes are occupations. The skill network links occupations by shared requirements; directed regional mobility links are observed occupation-to-occupation job switches. Following Tóth et al., SAM is the ROC-AUC of skill similarity predicting above-expected transition links, measured before a shock. The outcome is the change in consistently defined party-family vote shares between comparable elections. We would regress this on pre-shock SAM, negative shock exposure and their interaction, with controls for prior voting, unemployment, education, income, urbanisation and industrial structure. Shock exposure could use initial sector employment shares interacted with national sector employment changes excluding the region. Results would be associational, not causal.

4. Data feasibility and Hungary as Plan B

Cross-country administrative microdata require institutional approvals; at present, access and harmonised subnational coverage are unconfirmed. As a concrete fallback, Hungary's KRTK Admin4 database is a roughly 50% random population panel (6.35 million people), with linked monthly employment histories for 2003–2021 and employment coverage extending into 2022. It records employers, occupations (FEOR), earnings and spells outside employment. With suitable geographic identifiers and a FEOR–ISCO mapping, we could estimate SAM for Hungarian labour-market regions. We could combine these with the National Election Office's official 2022 results and earlier elections, e.g. compare 2018–2022 vote changes with pre-2020 SAM and exposure to the 2020 shock. The key checks would be regional coverage, temporal alignment and how party coalitions affect comparable vote-share measures. If local SAM is noisy, use larger regions and a simpler measure of the average skill similarity of observed job transitions.

5. Expected findings and relevance

We expect employment shocks to be followed by larger electoral shifts in places where workers' realized mobility is less aligned with transferable skills. A null finding would suggest SAM adds little beyond standard labour-market indicators. Results could help researchers and regional policymakers distinguish unemployment from limited career-adjustment opportunities; aggregate election results cannot reveal individual voters' motivations.

References

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Data documentation: OECD (2025), International Migration Outlook, ch. 4; Hublet & Chiecchio (2026), BLUE_DB; Boza, Pető & Tir (2026), Admin4.